disapproved entirely of this proposal. For London was aware that, in October 1920, an Afghan representative, Muhammad Wali Khan, had been despatched to Moscow to negotiate an agreement with the Soviet government.[70] In the eyes of some British officials, signing an agreement with Russia, while negotiating another with India, appeared too much like the traditional Afghan technique of playing one of its neighbouring countries off against the other (a definite legacy of the Great Game). To Whitehall, a mission sent to Kabul would risk being exposed 'to humiliation and misrepresentation'. Nevertheless, in the end the Home government was unwilling to overrule the Indian government and authorised the Kabul mission, should the viceroy insist on it.[71] (Although Chelmsford was somewhat hurt that his policy had 'not secured the whole-hearted support of His Majesty's Government').[72]

Afghan duplicity aside, one of the main concerns for Britain, when it came to a Soviet-Afghan treaty, was what practical gains the Soviet government could make from such an agreement. As Montagu noted, the Bolsheviks were not 'going to agree to pay the Afghans money from mere love of Afghanistan'.[73] The biggest worry for Britain was to be Article V of the treaty, which allowed Soviet Russia to open consulates close to the Indian frontier, including at Kandahar, for example.[74] It was undoubted that such establishments would become centres of Bolshevik intrigue directed south, towards India, and both Delhi and London agreed that these consulates should not be allowed to open.[75] For the Home government, the consulates were also an important sign of friendship developing between Soviet Russia and Afghanistan. For many British government figures imbued with Great Game thinking, it was simply inconceivable that Afghanistan could maintain equally friendly relations with both Russia and India. History dictated that one or other nation had to be dominant in Afghanistan; London's biggest fear was finding itself in the subordinate role.

It was this worry that led the Home government to demand, as a prerequisite to negotiating a treaty with Britain, that the Afghan government make a full disclosure of any agreement it had with Soviet Russia. Rather than wanting to know the details of what was contained within the document, the Home government saw this as a matter of principle.[76] As